

Aspects of Nigerian Confessional Poetry: An Overview

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Abstract

This essay attempts to draw attention to the reality of a new literary tradition within contemporary Nigerian poetry. Since the middle of the 2010s contemporary Nigerian poetry has seen a shift from the strident, public-oriented poetics of the second and to a large extent the third generations of Nigerian poets. The aesthetics of this shift consists primarily in the extreme intimacy and self-revelatory nature of the poetry of the fourth generation Nigerian poets, and in the clarity of the language they deploy. The poets have been called "Nigerian confessional poets" by critics such as Otorisize Obi-Young (2019) and Paul Liam (2022). Indeed, the significant strands of contemporary Nigerian poetry are confessional. This paper therefore seeks to assess the new poets' themes and poetic styles, and to highlight how they deviate from Nigeria's two dominant poetic traditions. The paper concludes that the new poets constitute a new school of Nigerian poetry, one that redefines the field by foregrounding subjectivity, vulnerability and the body amid complex pressures of the family and society.

Keywords: Nigerian poetic traditions, Nigerian confessional poetics, globalisation, social media, individualism, psychoanalysis

Introduction

A generation is typically conceived as a biological, cultural, and social construct that encompasses individuals of roughly the same age who are influenced by shared sociopolitical and cultural realities (Dimmick, 1951). Yet, when this notion is applied to a nation's cultural history, especially within literary studies, it presents significant challenges. Two interpretive dimensions emerge in defining a generation. The first is synchronic, referring to the conscious identity of a group who either recognize themselves or are recognized by others as a generation because of their shared participation in the events, conventions, and worldview of a given historical moment. The second is diachronic, linked to cultural memory and genealogy, in which a generation is constituted through inherited experiences and its responses to earlier traditions. In this sense, a generation is shaped as much by continuity with the past as by its reaction to it.

The difficulty with both approaches is that they complicate attempts to situate contemporary literary history within neatly defined generational categories. As Albert Thibaudet explains, literary generations do not operate with fixed beginnings and endings but rather belong to an ongoing continuity. Critical discourse, in seeking to create abstractions that structure idealized realities, plays a role in constructing these categories (Thibaudet, 2017).

Building on this idea, Oluwafunmilayo Miriam Akinpelu, in her thesis *From Postcolonial to Global Trajectories: Nigerian Novels and the Literary Generational Historical*, cites Ralph Dimmick's identification of seven key conditions necessary for defining a literary generation.

These include contemporaneity in age, comparable educational and institutional backgrounds, simultaneous attainment of artistic maturity, and the publication of significant works within the same time frame. Other factors are interpersonal connections through political engagement and leadership, linguistic uniformity, and emergence at the brink of a defining generational event that unites their creative output (Akinpelu, 2021).

Dimmick's criteria, as interpreted by Akinpelu, emphasize notions of “same-ness, similarity, congruence, and coherence” (Akinpelu, 2021). However, such neat classification is challenged by the overlapping themes and stylistic techniques that cut across literary eras. For this reason, some critics question the necessity of demarcating strict boundaries. Hannish Dalley, for instance, argues that many texts develop spatial and temporal frameworks that resist placement within critical models based solely on categories such as “generation” or “nation” (Dalley, 2013).

Critical discussions of national literatures often rely on historicist methods that divide and order creative works along chronological and epochal lines. In Nigerian literary studies, this typically takes the form of the national-generational paradigm, where writers are grouped into distinct cohorts presumed to share aesthetic orientations and to reflect different phases of national literary development. Pius Adesanmi and Chris Dunton defend the generational model for its capacity to clarify literary trends and shifts “synchronically and diachronically” (Adesanmi and Dunton, 2008). Within this framework, Nigerian writers of the past eight decades are usually organized into three generations: the first, second, and third. Alternatively, these categories are sometimes aligned with political epochs such as the pre-independence, post-independence, and military eras.

Still, the limitations of this model are widely acknowledged. Harry Garuba cautions that the term “generations” functions primarily as a descriptive convenience, not as a rigid boundary marker between groups of writers (Garuba, 1988). Similarly, Sule Egya recognizes the practical value of the paradigm but warns that “theme and style as markers of a specific literary period are inadequate, especially in modern African literatures” due to the influence of complex external contexts (Egya, 2019). Ode Ogede echoes this critique, observing that scholars rarely agree on the criteria for defining generations, whether based on form, theme, or historical period (Ogede, 2023). Yet, Ogede also emphasizes the usefulness of the national-generational approach for mapping how writers negotiate their literary inheritances, whether by conserving, revising, parodying, or transforming them into new creative cultures (Ogede, 2023).

This paper therefore employs the generational model not as an absolute framework but as a spatiotemporal category that identifies writers who share similar worldviews shaped by common social, political, and artistic circumstances. While some scholars, such as Nwachukwu Obiwu and Garuba, have argued for as many as five or four generations of Nigerian literature (Obiwu, 2009; Garuba, 2005), the more widely accepted division recognizes three. The first spans roughly 1960 to the civil war years, the second from the 1970s into the 1980s, and the third from the late 1980s through the early 2000s. Writers emerging after this period, including those at the center of this study, are sometimes still classified as “third generation” authors, though their thematic and stylistic departures suggest the rise of a distinct fourth generation.

At any rate, poets such as Romeo Oriogun, Adedayo Agarau, Nnamdi Samuel, Saddiq Dzukoji,

J .K. Anowe Logan February Gbenga Adesina, D. M. Aderibigbe and several others who emerged on the scene after 2015 would seem to constitute a distinct group within what some critics might still categorise as “the third generation writers”. In contrast to earlier Nigerian poetic traditions that foregrounded collective struggles, communal memory and the nation as the focus of meaning, these poets situate the self as the primary site of poetic exploration. Rather than drawing primarily from indigenous or nationalist frameworks, these poets appear indebted to American confessional poetry. Their verse foregrounds personal struggles, trauma, sexual entanglements and mental illness-subjects historically marginalized within Nigerian poetic discourse.

Theoretical Considerations: Confessional Poetry, Subjectivity and Trauma

The term "confessional poetry" itself remains contested within literary studies. Although frequently associated with American poets such as Robert Lowell, Sylvia Plath, Anne Sexton and John Berryman, critics have long debated whether confession refers primarily to subject matter, poetic technique, authorial self-disclosure, or a particular relationship between poetry and autobiography. M. L. Rosenthal, who first popularised the term in his review of Lowell's *Life Studies* (1959), identified confession as a mode in which private experiences traditionally excluded from poetry become central artistic material. Later scholars, however, have complicated this understanding by arguing that confessional poetry should not be read as direct autobiography. Rather, the confessional speaker is a textual construct, a performed self that selectively organizes experience into narrative and symbolic forms.

Such a perspective is especially useful for understanding contemporary Nigerian poetry. While these poets frequently draw upon personal experiences, their poems do not simply reproduce lived reality. Instead, they transform subjective experiences into aesthetic performances of identity. As Sidonie Smith and Julia Watson observe, autobiographical narratives do not merely represent the self; they actively produce it through acts of narration. The lyric "I" therefore becomes a site where memory, desire, trauma, fantasy and cultural expectation intersect.

This conception of confession is particularly relevant in postcolonial societies where individual identity is often negotiated against strong communal, familial and national narratives. The emergence of Nigerian confessional poetry may thus be understood not merely as a stylistic development but as part of a broader cultural shift toward new forms of selfhood. In this regard, the poetry reflects what Anthony Giddens describes as the "reflexive project of the self," a condition of late modernity in which identity becomes an ongoing process of self-examination and self-construction.

Methodology

This paper adopts a qualitative, interpretive approach grounded in close textual analysis. The poems selected for discussion were chosen purposively rather than statistically. The selection was guided by three principal criteria. First, the poems had to be representative of the dominant thematic and stylistic tendencies associated with contemporary Nigerian confessional poetry, particularly self-revelation, psychological introspection, bodily experience, grief, sexuality, familial conflict, and personal trauma. Second, the selected poets have emerged as some of the most visible voices in contemporary Nigerian poetry since the mid-2010s and have received

considerable critical attention in literary journals, online magazines, and scholarly discussions. Third, the poems chosen provide a broad spectrum of confessional expression, encompassing psychoanalytic self-exploration (O. Jeremiah Agbaakin, Samuel Adeyemi), socio-political confession (J. K. Anowe), familial trauma (Adedayo Agarau), queer subjectivity (Nnadi Samuel, Romeo Oriogun), mourning and elegy (Gbenga Adesina and Saddiq Dzukogi), and autobiographical narration (Agarau).

The paper employs close reading as its primary analytical method while drawing theoretical insights from psychoanalysis, trauma studies, autobiography studies, queer theory, and scholarship on confessional poetry. Rather than treating the poems as transparent autobiographical documents, the study follows contemporary literary critics who regard confession as a literary performance through which subjectivity is constructed, negotiated, and narrated. The poems are therefore examined not as factual records of lived experience but as aesthetic artefacts that transform personal experiences into literary forms capable of generating broader cultural meanings.

The Socio-Political Context that Shaped the Emergence of the New Poets

The rise of these poets cannot be separated from Nigeria's socio-political trajectory since 1999. The country's return to democracy opened cultural spaces for new expressions while digital technologies and social media globalised literary voices in unprecedented ways. Unlike earlier generations the Fourth generation poets came of age in the era of social media, a context that encouraged personal expression and valorization of individual perspective.

Otosirieze Obi-Young highlights this shift through the work of J. K. Anowe, noting that although he engages broad themes such as politics and culture, he simultaneously opens space for “realities that were previously thought to be unworthy of notice,” including the psychic burdens of depression and suicidal ideation (Obi-Young, 2019). Such concerns reflect broader postmodern currents, particularly the cultural diffusion made possible by globalisation and online technologies. As Peter Takov and Ngoran Mathew Banlanjo observe, postmodernism's “emphasis on individual autonomy... its romance with shifting meanings” has radically altered African cultural and ethical frameworks (Takov and Banlanjo, 2021).

Liam elsewhere provides historical grounding for the rise of this confessional mode, observing that the 2010s marked “a drastic change towards individualism and confessionalism,” as poets sought self-realisation in the midst of social precarity (Liam, 2023). For many, the bleak literary infrastructure at home accelerated the turn outward. Oris Aigbokhaevbolo captures this in his controversial essay *The Death of Nigerian Literature*, noting that publishers, starved of readership, often “battle with reader apathy” and prefer to recycle titles already successful in the West (Aigbokhaevbolo, 2023). Facing this reality, many poets sought MFA programs abroad or published in American literary journals, thereby deepening the influence of foreign poetics.

This reliance on Western frameworks has provoked sharp criticism. Ernest O. Ogunyemi argues that Nigerian poets have grown indifferent to their immediate environment, neglecting “such simple Nigerian things as the generator, the woman selling fish, and the man who talks too loudly in the compound” (Ogunyemi, 2023). For Ogunyemi, this signals a loss of literary intimacy with Nigerian everyday life. Liam adds a formal critique, asserting that “poetry has

lost its nuances and the magisterial opulence of its language,” reduced instead to a kind of “prose-poetry or pseudo-poetry” (Liam, 2021).

These critiques intersect with postmodern debates over the erosion of grand narratives. Jean-François Lyotard famously theorised postmodernism as “incredulity toward metanarratives” (Lyotard, 1979), a condition reflected in Nigerian confessional poets' preference for fragmentation, instability, and self-exploration. Oko Owi Ocho interprets this shift as symptomatic of “the crisis of the death of grand narratives” within contemporary literature (Ocho, 2023). In response, Bestman Michael Osemudiamen defends the confessional poets, rejecting what he sees as narrow, chauvinistic calls for a wholesale return to African authenticity. For Osemudiamen, “what has become our reality in this modern age of artificial intelligence, globalisation, and digitisation, cannot be founded on principles around identity/cultural chauvinism, we cannot return to the past” (Osemudiamen, 2023).

The debate recalls the ideological rifts of the 1980s between Chinweizu and Wole Soyinka, underscoring the enduring contestation between art, tradition, and modernity. Critics variously object to content (Ogunyemi, 2023), style and form (Liam, 2021 Chukwudera, 2024), or ideology (Ocho, 2023), while others like Osemudiamen emphasise the inevitability of global cultural flows. Arasi Kamolideen Oluwapelumi pushes the debate further, focusing less on cultural allegiance than on literary craft. He argues that neither “the Nigerian elements” nor Western forms guarantee artistic accomplishment; only “the imagination, cognition and execution therein” determine the literary value of new writing (Oluwapelumi, 2024).

Despite these disputes, there is broad consensus that the new poets represent a transformative force in Nigerian literature. Their confessional mode reflects not only the impact of globalisation but also Nigeria's own social dislocations. As Edward Said reminds us, “authors are products of their time and place” (Said, 1970); the introspective turn of contemporary Nigerian poetry mirrors both the possibilities of the digital age and the precarities of Nigerian social life. The poets' insistence on self-expression within a society long oriented toward communal identity, what Clifford Geertz once described as the cultural embedding of the self in family and community structures (Geertz, 1973), signals the profound transformations reshaping African modernity.

In cultural terms, their work reflects a shift from collective consciousness to individual subjectivity. While earlier Nigerian poets wrote against colonial oppression or military dictatorship, these poets dramatise alienation, private grief, and sexuality as central themes. In this sense, they register what Jean-François Lyotard calls the “postmodern condition,” where grand narratives lose their authority and the micro-narratives of individuals become legitimate sources of meaning.

Themes, Styles and Features in the Fourth Generation Nigerian Poetry

The poet's insistence on self-expression within a society long oriented toward communal identity, what Clifford Geertz once described as the cultural embedding of the self in family and community structures (Geertz, 1973), signals the profound transformation reshaping African modernity. The fourth generation Nigerian poets inaugurate something almost entirely new in Nigerian literature: a self-centred poetics that views the world primarily through the prism of

personal perspective and subjective experience. While earlier generations of Nigerian poets frequently conceived of the individual as inseparable from larger social, political, and communal realities, many contemporary poets have increasingly turned inward, making the private self the central site of poetic inquiry. This movement represents not merely a stylistic shift but a significant reorientation of poetic consciousness. The contemporary lyric voice no longer speaks predominantly as the representative of a people, nation, or collective historical condition; rather, it speaks as an individual grappling with the complexities of memory, trauma, desire, anxiety, and psychological fragmentation.

One of the most striking features of this emerging poetic tradition is its remarkable psychoanalytic depth. Contemporary Nigerian poets display an unprecedented interest in the hidden recesses of the mind, exploring emotional states that often resist rational explanation. Their poems frequently function as acts of self-analysis, exposing the tensions, wounds, and contradictions that shape individual subjectivity. Here is an excerpt from O. Jeremiah Agbaakin's poem, "Porcupines":

*I pull hard at the harp like an archer
\$ let go everything sharp, everything
with an edge in me, everything that
has a fang but not a tongue of its own
my grief is not wind-borne
I hurl this concave cymbals like a boomerang
on its leash...*

The poem dramatizes a struggle with buried psychic material seeking release. The persona blows hard at the harp, trying to evacuate from his inner being all the pent-up emotions arising from some deeply buried trauma. The imagery of sharp objects, fangs, and edged instruments suggests the violence of internal conflict, while the act of musical performance becomes a symbolic process of catharsis. The speaker seeks not merely to express grief but to externalise it, transforming emotional pain into artistic form. The poem therefore exemplifies what Cathy Caruth describes as the paradoxical nature of traumatic narration, wherein language circles around wounds that remain difficult to articulate directly. Trauma emerges not through explicit description but through metaphor, displacement, and repetition. Agbaakin's language captures this condition by presenting grief as something lodged within the self, demanding release yet resisting complete expression.

The prominence of psychological interiority in these poems invites interpretation through trauma studies. Trauma theorists such as Cathy Caruth, Dominick LaCapra, and Shoshana Felman argue that traumatic experience frequently exceeds immediate comprehension and returns belatedly through fragmented memories, compulsive repetitions, and symbolic displacements. Trauma often manifests itself not through coherent narration but through gaps, silences, ruptures and recurrent images. Contemporary Nigerian confessional poetry exhibits precisely these features. The poems rarely narrate traumatic events directly; rather, they circle around psychic wounds through fragmented syntax, recurring metaphors and emotional discontinuities.

This tendency is especially significant in a Nigerian context marked by economic precarity,

social instability, religious tensions, migration, family disintegration and various forms of collective violence. While earlier Nigerian poetry often represented these realities through public and political discourse, contemporary confessional poets increasingly register their effects on the individual psyche. The result is a poetry that translates historical and social crises into intimate experiences of anxiety, grief, depression and emotional fragmentation.

The psychological orientation of such poetry reflects broader changes in contemporary Nigerian society. Rapid urbanisation, globalisation, migration, economic uncertainty, and the expansion of digital culture have all contributed to the increasing prominence of individual consciousness as a literary concern. The contemporary subject often appears isolated from traditional communal structures and compelled to confront existential questions alone. Consequently, the poem becomes a privileged space for negotiating identity, recording emotional vulnerability, and examining the fragmented nature of selfhood in modern life.

Samuel A. Adeyemi is another poet who explores the aesthetics of melancholy as a means of constructing poetic selves. In his poem “It Comes in Waves,” he writes:

*Like any fatherless
ache, the origin of*

*My displacement is
untraceable: the finger
Samuel A. Adeyemi
working the puzzle
of my life, going in*

*circles. I am mostly
irritable in my crisis.
Room full of smoke,
but I cannot find*

*the fire. The wisps,
blue, mellowing*

*in every damn cell.
I have to justify*

*my anger. Every
martyr should know*

*the nexus of their
torture. We should*

*point at the heart
of our agony & say,*

I have found where

the rain began. All

*I see is the torrent,
the sky's wet proof.
It comes in waves,
crashing inside*

*my head, the arrows
pouring from every
cloud. First, the fire,
now the flood. Ash
water possessing me.
Again, vexation.
I see the for the
cowardice of disorder.
How chaos is both
present & obscure.*

The emotional force of these lines derives largely from their formal structure. The clipped syntax and short lines create a sense of interruption and incompleteness, mirroring the speaker's psychological state. Meaning unfolds hesitantly, as though the persona is struggling to assemble fragments of a broken narrative. The image of displacement without a traceable origin evokes a crisis of identity in which the self becomes detached from stable sources of meaning. Equally significant is the metaphor of life as a puzzle whose pieces resist arrangement. The finger "going in circles" suggests an endless search for coherence, a repetitive movement characteristic of melancholic consciousness.

The direction of the statement and the clipped effect of the short lines are evidence of the persona's frustrations and mental paralysis. Yet the poem does more than document suffering; it transforms suffering into a mode of self-knowledge. Through introspection, the speaker attempts to understand the origins of emotional pain and existential uncertainty. The poem thus becomes a space where psychic wounds are simultaneously displayed and interrogated.

This is poetry of interior landscapes, of self-probing and autobiographical discourse. The self is not presented as coherent or stable but as fractured, unfinished, and perpetually in the process of becoming. Such representations resonate strongly with psychoanalytic theories of subjectivity, particularly those that understand identity as constituted through absence, lack, and unconscious desire. The contemporary Nigerian lyric increasingly privileges these unstable dimensions of experience, foregrounding doubt, vulnerability, and emotional complexity.

This confessional mode, while rooted in Western literary traditions associated with writers such as Sylvia Plath, Robert Lowell, and Anne Sexton, acquires new resonances within the Nigerian context. Rather than merely imitating Western models, these poets adapt confessional strategies to address local experiences of displacement, social transition, familial rupture, and cultural change. The result is a distinctive poetic idiom in which personal experience becomes a lens for understanding wider transformations in contemporary society. This paradigm shift suggests that Nigerian poetry is undergoing a profound transformation, moving away from collective

identities toward the fractured, unstable identities of the self. In doing so, it opens new possibilities for representing subjectivity and expands the emotional and psychological horizons of Nigerian literary expression

Apart from writing about self-exploration and identity, Nigerian confessional poets also write about social issues and politics, but mostly from a very personal perspective. J.K. Anowe, perhaps the most influential among his contemporaries in his poem "Love in the Time of Arrests" dramatises a crisis of being that fuses personal despair with systemic collapse. He writes:

*The orderlies come in them tens
I am just one man*

one poet

*honed to one poem
that is the sentence of my life
or where it departs
25 with no job prospects
I lie palpable.*

*You corded like a coma
by my side.*

*In my mother's old couch
The same one we've sat on to blow stiff
on the government...*

Anowe's poem resists a single-axis reading; it is simultaneously a love poem, a social protest and a psychoanalytic confession. The poet's speaker, a 25 year old without employment, situates his crisis with a world where economic dispossession and moral exhaustion converge. The 'orderlies' signify the psychiatric and moral apparatuses of a society that polices deviances, while the mother's 'old couch' becomes a repression space-at once warm and prison –where love, madness and revolt collide. The persona as his lover live in an environment where emotional intimacy becomes suspect and where resistance to order (social, religious, economic) is pathologised as madness. The poet's 'armed' is thus both ideal and metaphysical; the body restraint, the mind medicated, the voice silenced. The couple's suicide at the end of the poem becomes the ultimate refusal of conformity, the last act of agency in a world that has confiscated all others.

Another common thread that runs through Nigerian confessional poetry is the conflicted family unit, particularly the alienated father and central, often wounded mother. The father frequently appears as a figure of absence, estrangement or violence, while the mother embodies intimacy, suffering or excessive closeness. For instance Adedayo Agarau's long poem, "A Poetry Cover of Billie Eilish's 'No Time to Die' in which I am Ghost haunting My Father's New Home" encapsulates these themes. The poet writes:

*I watch my mother's eyes
as everything settles in the turbulence of her boy
as a good child. I put my faith between my palms
\$ rub them together.
Who is on your side when you are at war
I am with everyone in this room
Our still shadows itching to jump out of fire.*

The persona in the poem empathises with his mother for being physically abused by his father. He prays to God to deliver her from the cruelty, but it seems God is taking a while to do so. Things have come to such a pass at home that the persona seems to resent everyone. In fact everybody wishes to be rid of everyone, 'Itching to jump out of our fire'. The word 'fire' is both a literal and symbolic one. The speaker mentally associates his father with fire. Agara's poem exemplifies what happens when an individual is exposed to extreme physical and psychic situations. The poem's persona is full of anguish, vague discontents and confusion, and an inner emptiness yearning to be filled with some transcendent experience. Other poets who have thematised familial alienation in their poetry are J.K. Anowe in his 'Aubade with Purgatory' and 'Tender Crow's Feet', Romeo Oriogun in his 'Genesis' and 'Sacrifice' and O-Jeremiah Agbaakin in his volume *The Sign of the Ram*. Indeed, the view of father as despotic and troublesome pervades much contemporary Nigerian poetry.

The recurring figure of the troubled father in contemporary Nigerian confessional poetry may also be interpreted through psychoanalytic frameworks. Freud's account of paternal authority, Lacan's concept of the "Name-of-the-Father," and later object-relations theorists such as Melanie Klein all emphasize the formative role of familial relationships in the construction of subjectivity. In many contemporary Nigerian poems, the father appears less as an individual than as a symbolic figure representing authority, discipline, patriarchy, religion, and social expectation. The conflict between father and child therefore becomes a conflict between the self and the structures that seek to regulate it.

Moreover, these poems frequently reveal what trauma scholars describe as intergenerational transmission. The wounds experienced by one generation continue to shape the emotional lives of subsequent generations. Familial violence, emotional neglect, and patriarchal control become psychic inheritances carried by the poetic subject. The confessional poem functions as a space where these inherited traumas are acknowledged, interrogated and, in some cases, transformed into forms of artistic resistance. **120**

In the poetry of queer poets such as Romeo Oriogun and Nnadi Samuel, the father frequently emerges as the embodiment of rigid masculinity and patriarchal authority, a figure whose prescriptions concerning gender and sexuality must be resisted and dismantled. The father becomes more than a biological parent; he represents the social order that polices bodies, regulates desire, and enforces heteronormative expectations. This tension between the queer self and patriarchal authority leads naturally to another important dimension of Nigerian confessional poetry: the reclamation of the body as a site of pleasure, resistance, and self-definition. The emergence of queer confessional poetry in Nigeria represents one of the most significant developments in contemporary African literature. Scholars such as Eve Kosofsky Sedgwick and Judith Butler have demonstrated how sexuality is not simply a private matter but

a field through which power, identity and social norms are negotiated. Confession becomes particularly important for queer subjects because it enables the articulation of identities historically subjected to silence, invisibility, and social sanction.

Within the Nigerian context, where non-heteronormative sexualities remain highly contested, queer confession acquires an additional political dimension. The revelation of desire is never merely personal; it is simultaneously an act of self-definition and cultural resistance. Consequently, the body occupies a privileged position within the poetry. It becomes the site where competing forces of desire, shame, religion, family, and state authority converge.¹²⁰

In the following lines from Nnadi Samuel's poem, the conflict between queer identity and paternal authority is vividly dramatized:

*Lust as corporal punishment, implies
We kneel on each other for pleasure
Boy: a gadget I stomach on sighting my father
watch he pull the least
non-binary stunt I'm capable of.*

*I – doubled-edged – pronoun, perishable fish
Pal tells me – 'smithe everything that points
towards your thigh'
My knees, polished into amazement...*

*I arch my back with ripe grace & fell into shape
a rebuttal to the soft-meated claim, that:*

*a) ache is tenderised hardship
b) thigh at rest is hot argument lying-in state.
c) All thighs in motion becomes dangerous physics
the mechanical grease of skin, alarming Pa in all
the right places.*

The persona in these lines does not merely expose the vulnerability of being queer in Nigeria; he also revels in queer pleasure as a deliberate act of resistance. The poem rejects shame and secrecy by transforming the body into a language of self-affirmation. Images such as the “doubled-edged” pronoun and the “thigh in motion” suggest an identity that refuses stable categorization and embraces fluidity. Significantly, the father's alarm becomes evidence of the poem's success. The body that patriarchal culture seeks to discipline instead becomes a source of defiance and creative power.

Samuel repeatedly returns to this strategy in poems such as “*Chaos Theory*” and “*My Body is Not Yours to Offer*,” where bodily experience becomes inseparable from political resistance. Desire is not represented as private indulgence but as a challenge to systems that seek to regulate who may love, desire, or belong. The confessional mode allows the poet to transform personal experience into a broader critique of social norms. As Judith Butler argues, “performativity is not a singular act but a repetition and a ritual” (xv). Samuel's poetry embodies precisely such a ritual. Each confession becomes an act of resistance; each articulation of queer desire contests

erasure and reclaims visibility.

Together with contemporaries such as Romeo Oriogun and Logan February, Samuel has expanded the possibilities of Nigerian poetry by bringing queer subjectivities into literary visibility with an audacity rarely witnessed before. Their candid representations of bisexual, queer, and non-binary experiences challenge cultural taboos and confront the long-standing silence surrounding non-heterosexual identities in Nigerian literature. In doing so, they redefine the confessional tradition itself, transforming it into a space where marginalized bodies can speak, desire, and exist on their own terms.

Saddiq Dzukogi and Gbenga Adesina perhaps embody the elegiac tradition in contemporary Nigerian literature. The best of their poetry is much influenced by the very personal experiences, especially the loss of their loved ones – in the case of Adesina his father and Dzukogi his daughter. Their poems are not only memorial, for the dead but also therapeutic acts of survival. The prominence of elegy within contemporary Nigerian confessional poetry may also be situated within a broader tradition of mourning literature. Freud's distinction between mourning and melancholia remains particularly illuminating here. Whereas mourning involves the gradual acceptance of loss, melancholia is characterized by an inability fully to detach from the lost object. Contemporary Nigerian elegiac poetry frequently oscillates between these two states. The dead remain psychologically present, inhabiting memories, dreams, objects and bodily sensations.

Recent grief theorists such as David Eng and David Kazanjian have further argued that loss may generate new forms of attachment rather than closure. Such a perspective helps explain why the dead continue to occupy central positions in the poetry of Adesina and Dzukogi. Their poems do not seek to overcome grief but to inhabit it, transforming mourning into an enduring relationship with memory.

In *Painter of Water*, a volume of poems dedicated to the memory of his father, Adesina tries to impress upon the reader the very physicality of his grief, the function telling corporeal expression of the pain of loss. In the poem 'Thirteen ways of Naming My Father's Body' he writes:

*My father's body know pleasure. It lasted like
thorn on his flesh.*

*Once on a bus, a child smiled at me, and I knew
it was my father's body.*

*On some days, the morning is my father's body
I wear it like loneliness.*

*When I'm dancing and twisting in the dark,
my father's body joins me. He brings in night
at his dance picture.*

Adesina's poem recalls Wallace Steven's 'Thirteen Ways of Looking at a Black Bird', and this

intertextual gesture situates the poem in a broader modernist tradition of fragmentation and multiplicity. By echoing Stevens, Adesina underscores that grief like perception, cannot be exhausted in a single image or expression but must be approached through a constellation of perspectives. Through the use of specific metaphors to enrich the depth of his expression, Adesina allows the reader to experience the pain of loss, with the body of the father serving as 'truth texts' through which he explores the memories of his father on the idle hand in Dzukogi's elegies in *Your Crib, My Qibla*, the corporeal aspect of mourning is less emphasised; instead he uses pain, grief and memory as tropes in the poems. The perceptions, thoughts and feelings expressed in the poems are contemplations of an individual coming to terms with the loss of his beloved object and the recognition of the irretrievability of that object. Dzukogi brings into Nigerian poetry an Islamic sensibility and worldview, dimensions often absent within the genre.

The inward turn that Nigerian poetry has taken in recent years has coincided with, and perhaps necessitated, a corresponding narrative turn. The confessional impulse requires not only introspection but narration, for the self can only become intelligible through stories about its experiences, memories, losses and desires. Consequently, many contemporary Nigerian poets have adopted a mode in which lyric reflection and narrative progression exist side by side. Rather than presenting isolated images or highly compressed symbolic structures, these poets often construct scenes, recount events, and recreate conversations. The poem becomes a site where storytelling and self-examination meet. Among the poets who have demonstrated remarkable skill in this regard is Adedayo Agarau. In poems such as "Prelude; Christmas" and "Before the Dark," Agarau transforms seemingly ordinary moments from contemporary Nigerian life into narratives charged with emotional resonance and poetic beauty.

The excerpt from "Prelude; Christmas" illustrates Agarau's gift for observation and his ability to animate communal spaces:

*The mothers are weaving their hair & taking about
chickens. Iya Jide who has poultry with
twelve birds, says she is ready to sell her stock.
They are outside the hairdresser's shop,
decked in colourful bubu. The wall
of the complex is a painting of Fela Anikulapo
Kuti raising his hands in solidarity.
The women talk about their husbands...*

What is striking here is the poet's attention to the textures of everyday life. Nothing dramatic appears to be happening. Women gather outside a hairdresser's shop, discussing poultry, husbands and the economic calculations surrounding the festive season. Yet Agarau elevates this apparently mundane scene into poetry through the precision of his observation. The details accumulate gradually: the poultry stock, the colourful bubu, the mural of Fela Kuti. Together they create a vivid social landscape. The poem functions almost like a cinematic shot in which multiple layers of Nigerian life coexist within a single frame. Domestic concerns intersect with economic realities, while the image of Fela introduces a subtle political dimension. The result is a portrait of communal existence that is simultaneously intimate and socially revealing.

The excerpt alone, however, cannot fully convey the narrative sophistication of the poem.

Agarau's real achievement lies in his capacity to sustain such scenes over the course of an entire poem, allowing them to unfold organically while retaining lyric intensity. This achievement becomes even more apparent in "Before the Dark." Whereas "Prelude; Christmas" centres on a communal gathering, "Before the Dark" is more overtly personal, tracing emotional and psychological states through a sequence of remembered experiences and observations. The poem demonstrates how narrative can serve as a vehicle for meditation. Events are not presented merely for their own sake; they become occasions for reflection on vulnerability, uncertainty and survival.

One of the poem's greatest strengths is its handling of temporality. Rather than moving straightforwardly from one event to another, Agarau allows memory, perception and anticipation to intermingle. The narrative advances in fragments, mimicking the way consciousness itself works. Images emerge and recede, moments from the past converse with the present, and seemingly minor details acquire symbolic significance. This technique gives the poem a fluid quality that is distinctly lyrical even as it remains narrative. The reader is carried not only through a sequence of events but through a sequence of emotional states.

Equally noteworthy is Agarau's language. Because his poems often appear on the page as blocks of text and employ relatively straightforward diction, they may initially seem closer to prose than poetry. Such an impression, however, disappears upon a careful reading. The rhythm of the lines, the careful arrangement of images, and the subtle repetitions create a musical structure beneath the apparent simplicity. Agarau demonstrates that poetry need not rely on elevated diction or elaborate metaphorical density to achieve aesthetic power. His language derives its effectiveness from cadence, atmosphere and emotional precision.

Indeed, the blending of narrative and lyric modes evident in Agarau's work has become characteristic of much contemporary Nigerian poetry. Compared with the highly rhetorical and densely figurative verse that dominated significant strands of Nigerian poetry during the 1980s and 1990s, many younger poets have embraced a more conversational style. Their language seeks flexibility rather than grandeur, intimacy rather than declamation. Everyday speech enters the poem with unprecedented ease. Contractions, colloquialisms and informal expressions are freely employed. Similarly, conventional punctuation is often abandoned in favour of slashes, ampersands, numerals and unconventional spacing. These innovations reflect an effort to capture the rhythms of contemporary experience more directly and to narrow the distance between poetic language and ordinary speech.

The visual appearance of these poems reinforces this aesthetic shift. Rather than carefully segmented stanzas, many contemporary poems appear as dense textual blocks spread across the page. This form mirrors the fluid movement of thought and narrative, resisting the rigid formal structures associated with earlier poetic traditions. Yet such developments have not been universally welcomed. Critics such as Paul Liam, Michael Chiedoziem Chukwudera and Earnest O. Ogunyemi have expressed reservations about these stylistic tendencies, attributing them largely to the influence of contemporary American poetry. For these critics, the abandonment of traditional poetic markers risks blurring the distinction between poetry and prose.

Nevertheless, Agarau's poems suggest that this evolution should not be understood as a decline

in poetic craft but as a redefinition of it. The artistry resides not in rhetorical ornamentation but in the capacity to transform lived experience into aesthetically compelling narrative. Poems such as “Prelude; Christmas” and “Before the Dark” demonstrate that contemporary Nigerian poetry has discovered new possibilities within ordinary language and everyday life. Through their fusion of storytelling and lyric reflection, they reveal a poetry capable of capturing the complexities of modern Nigerian existence while remaining deeply attentive to the inner life of the self.

Conclusion

Viewed through the lenses of confessional poetics, psychoanalysis and trauma studies, contemporary Nigerian poetry appears not merely as a new thematic trend but as a significant reconfiguration of literary subjectivity. The confessional turn reflects changing understandings of identity in a globalized and digitally mediated world. It signals a movement away from collective nationalist paradigms toward a poetics concerned with vulnerability, memory, embodiment and psychic life. Yet these poems are not purely private. Their representations of grief, sexuality, family conflict, depression and desire reveal the ways in which larger social and historical forces become inscribed upon individual consciousness. Therefore, taken together, these poets constitute a new school of Nigerian poetry, one that redefines the field by foregrounding subjectivity, vulnerability, and the body. Unlike their predecessors, they do not present themselves as national spokespeople but as fractured selves negotiating personal and collective trauma. Ultimately, there are aspects to what might be categorised as 'Nigerian confessional poetics': there is the aspect in which the poet pursues his obsessive quest for his own individuality amidst the peremptory demands of the family and society (J.K. Anowe, Adedayo Agarau); there is the use of autobiographical elements as a way of projecting a poetic of liberation and exploration of non-normative sexualities (Nnamdi Samuel, Romeo Oriogun, Logan February); there is this aspect in which the poet explores intimately his religious (Islamic or Christian) upbringing in ways that shape his impressions of the world (Saddiq Dzukogi, Umar Sidi, O-Jeremiah Agbaakin), and lastly there is the aspect in which the poet explores public narratives in very intimate ways while grappling with the complexities of his identity and place within the public narratives (Rasak Malik Gbolahan, Kechi Nne Nomu). However, none of these aspects is exclusive to any particular poet. The poets in varying degrees encompass all these strands. After all, the poets are still evolving and growing.

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